THE SECURITY COUNCIL

Composition

CHAPTER V, in particular Article 23 of the Charter, embodies the provisions relating to the membership of the Council. It specifies that the Security Council shall consist of fifteen members of the United Nations. The Republic of China, France, the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (now Russia), the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland, and the United States of America shall be the permanent members of the Security Council. The admission of People's Republic of China did not take place immediately after the formation of UN due to American veto. At that time, Nationalist China (Taiwan) represented the State of China. However, with the recognition in 1971 of the Beijing Government by the UN, the People's Republic of China was finally admitted to the Council, displacing Taiwan.

The ten non-permanent members are elected by the General Assembly for two-year terms and they are not eligible for immediate re-election. The non-permanent members are selected on the basis of geographical distribution. They are chosen from Asian, African, Latin American and the Caribbean, East European and West European States. The number of non-permanent members was increased from six to ten by an amendment of the Charter, which came into force in 1965. Due regard is specially paid, in the first instance, to the contribution of the members of the United Nations to the maintenance of international peace and security and to the other purposes of the Organization, and also to equitable geographical distribution. Each member of the Security Council shall have one representative.

It has been pointed, however, that the structure of the Council is undemocratic and not based on the principle of sovereign equality. Only the number of non-permanent members was increased and not that of the permanent. Besides, the council has been given sweeping powers relating to the vital matters of international peace and security as compared to the Assembly.